Slow Signal

Thursday, November 5, 2026
Boston · High 75° · Low 57°

Vivid Void @vividvoid · Oct 6 IDEAS & LIFE

Psychedelic use, for most users, is part of a cycle of persistent grief. The grandeur of the neon sea of fractals and the ability to self-smash the infinite wonder button in the brain is, in fact, a sad consolation prize for having lost the ability to make meaning of the small, mundane circumstances of life.

Wild weekend swings between the light fantastic and its faltering, depleted aftermath recapitulate the broader oscillation between narcissism and nihilsm that characterizes contemporary life. The psychedelic trip, like all psychoses, promises a revelation that never quite comes, or insinuates a transmission that is never quite remembered. You know it's special. You know it's meaningful. It's completely, 100% yours. This time you'll find it for real. This time you'll be able to bring it back.

"I have come to know the deepest secrets of the universe," he thinks, bleary eyed in bed at 12:30 pm on a Sunday afternoon. "I have glimpsed the mind of God" she thinks, scrolling her stories, avoiding the certain overwhelm of reading an e-mail from a once beloved college roommate.

In the meantime, dust accumulates, calls go unanswered, dinner invitations go unsent, loved ones slowly disappear from life, one mild disappointment at a time. The chores that maintain half-decency become too boring, too meaningless, too immediately unrewarding to be worth the effort. And in that thorough and terrible neglect, the desert of honesty and care at the center of postmodern subjectivity yawns. The blistering infinite sacred, on-demand, and all it costs you is your will to show up for your mundane world, to keep trying to love your frustrating family, to try something, anything to rise above the infinite guilt of your unlived life.

Joe Hudson @FU_joehudson · Oct 1 IDEAS & LIFE

A student once told me: “One part of me thinks I’m better than almost anyone else, while another part believes that I’m never good enough.”

I hear this often, and so I'd like to share what I worked with him on:

Samurai Shiba @SamuraiShibaJP · Nov 4 IDEAS & LIFE

My wife has taught high school in Tokyo for twenty years.

Every year, a few of her students spend a year living with a family in America. When they come home, she asks each of them one question.

"What do you miss?"

She expects hamburgers.

She almost never gets hamburgers.

And these aren't old stories. Most of these kids came home in the last two years.

"Every time I left the house, my host mom said, 'Text me when you get there.' In Japan, nobody needs to know where I am. In Ohio, somebody always did." (Mina, 17, Ohio)

"If you walk toward a door, an American will hold it open. Even if you are very far away. So you have to run. I ran to so many doors." (Itsuki, 16, Georgia)

"My host brother screamed on the floor of a grocery store. A stranger walked by and said to my host mom, 'You're doing great, Mama.' She almost cried. I didn't know strangers were allowed to say that." (Aoi, 17, Texas)

"We went away for the weekend and left our trash can at the curb. When we got back, it was by the garage. Nobody said who. My host dad said if it had been there one more day, the neighbor would have knocked." (Haruto, 16, Minnesota)

"A car got stuck in the snow in front of our house. Four men came out of four houses. Nobody called them. They pushed, the car drove away, and they went back inside without saying their names." (Ren, 17, Michigan)

"Every American has jumper cables. Maybe half of them know which clip goes where. The other half help anyway." (Shin, 16, Montana)

"In July, my host family put a cooler on the porch. Cold water, snacks, and a sign: 'For our delivery drivers. Thank you!' I asked if they knew the drivers. They said no." (Nanami, 16, Arizona)

"Downtown, there are banners on the lampposts. Photos of soldiers from the town. Some old, some very young. My host grandpa walked me down the street and told me every name." (Yuna, 16, Iowa)

"I got a C-plus on my first test. My host dad said, 'I'm proud of you,' and put it on the fridge. In Japan, nobody is proud of a C-plus." (Takeru, 17, Pennsylvania)

Then the quietest girl in the class raised her hand.

Sora. Seventeen. Missouri.

"Nobody asks me 'home safe?' anymore," she said.

She was wrong.

In September, there was a typhoon warning for Tokyo. At 2 a.m., Sora's phone lit up.

It was her host mom. In Missouri. Watching the weather in a country she had never been to.

"Saw the storm. You home safe?"

Sora told my wife she cried for a long time. Then she typed the answer she had typed a hundred times, from football games and friends' driveways.

"Home safe."

Her host mom wrote back one line.

"Good. That's all I needed."

My wife has asked that question for twenty years. Not one kid has ever said they missed how big America is.

They miss how America says goodbye. And how it checks that you got home.

So, America. You think you've lost something.

You haven't. It's on a porch in Arizona. It's pushing a car in Michigan. It's awake at 2 a.m. in Missouri, watching our weather.

You don't remember doing any of it.

A kid in Tokyo will never forget.

Jake Kozloski @jakozloski · Nov 4

IDEAS & LIFE

Of unhappily married people who stayed together, two-thirds called the same marriage happy five years later. Of the very unhappy who stayed, nearly 8 in 10.

Divorced individuals were no happier.

Most rough patches are just patches. The rational move is usually to push through.

Study:

Paul Saladino, MD @paulsaladinomd · Nov 4

SCIENCE & HEALTH

established benefits of creatine:
-sleep deprivation - improved cognitive function (20-25g/day)
-strength, sprinting, lean muscle gain (1-2kg), muscle recovery (5g+/day)
-alzheimer's dz - improved cognitive function (20g/day)
-male fertility - improved sperm count (5g+/day)
-traumatic brain injury - cognitive improvements (25g+/day)

emerging benefits:
-cancer (animal models)
-skin aging (topical)
-heart failure
-depression
-fibromyalgia
-COPD
-osteoarthritis
-fatigue

these benefits are often more pronounced in women who tend to have lower endogenous stores.

no, creatine does not cause hair loss or worsen kidney function.

yes, you can (and should!) get it from red meat but few eat 2+lbs per day (approx 5g dose).

monohydrate form is most studied. dissolve in warm water if you get gi side effects.

if you are not taking creatine, you should be. get it from a 3rd party tested source!

Preethi Kasireddy @iam_preethi · Nov 3

SCIENCE & HEALTH

A man's belly fat changes the DNA his baby inherits.

Researchers looked at sperm from 71 men. The heavier men had nearly 39,000 changes in their sperm. Many of these changes were in genes that help build the baby's brain and placenta.

Unfat yourself before getting a woman pregnant.

Mad In America @Mad_In_America · Nov 4

SCIENCE & HEALTH

On the MIA #podcast we are joined by Sascha DuBrul, a leading activist in the psychiatric survivor movement for more than two decades. His interests lie at the intersection of the public mental health system and the Mad Underground.

Yun-Ta Tsai @yunta_tsai · Nov 4

SCIENCE & HEALTH

Perhaps humanity's voyage into space is less an act of exploration and more a Mayflower moment to carry the seeds of civilization to a new world.

Trad West @trad_west_ · Nov 4

BOOKS & FAITH

Jim Caviezel: "Embrace your cross. Go out into this pagan world and shamelessly profess your faith in public."

Christ is Lord!

. . .

That's all for today.

All posts are from X, quoted in full as posted.